American Sovereign Bullion

THE QUIET EROSION

Why Your Money Buys Less Every Year,
and What Prudent Savers Are Quietly Doing to Protect It

A PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE TO INFLATION, YOUR RETIREMENT, AND PHYSICAL PRECIOUS METALS

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> ***A note before you begin.*** *This guide takes about fifteen minutes to read. No hype. No doomsday predictions. It explains one thing carefully, so that when you finish, you can make a calm and informed decision about your own money. Is fifteen minutes of your time worth finding out whether forty years of savings needs protecting?*

SECTION 1

You Have Already Noticed This

Open the drawer where you keep your important papers. Somewhere in there is a bank statement, or a pension letter, or a Social Security notice, with a number printed on it. That number is a kind of promise. It says: this is what you have. This is what forty years of work bought you.

Here is the hard thing nobody at the bank will say to your face. That number is telling you a lie. Not about the amount. About what the amount is worth.

You have felt it already. The cart of groceries that used to run sixty dollars and now runs a hundred. The gas, the insurance, the property tax, the quiet arithmetic at the end of every month that never used to be this tight. Your income did not shrink. Your statement did not drop. And yet somehow there is less. Less cushion, less room, less of the retirement you pictured for yourself.

You did nothing wrong. You saved. You were careful. You played by the rules they handed you. The problem is not you. The problem is the dollar itself, and the slow, silent way it has been eroding the value of every account you own, year after year, while the number on the page sat perfectly still and told you everything was fine.

This guide is about that erosion. Where it comes from, why it is speeding up, and what a small but growing number of careful, unpanicked people are doing right now to protect the part of their savings they cannot afford to lose. Let us start with where the erosion comes from.

The more of it they print, the less of it you have.

SECTION 2

Where the Money Goes

Here is the part they do not teach at the kitchen table.
For all the millennia mankind has worked with money, the men who ran it had been through the challenge before. Dollars were golden. There was a map.

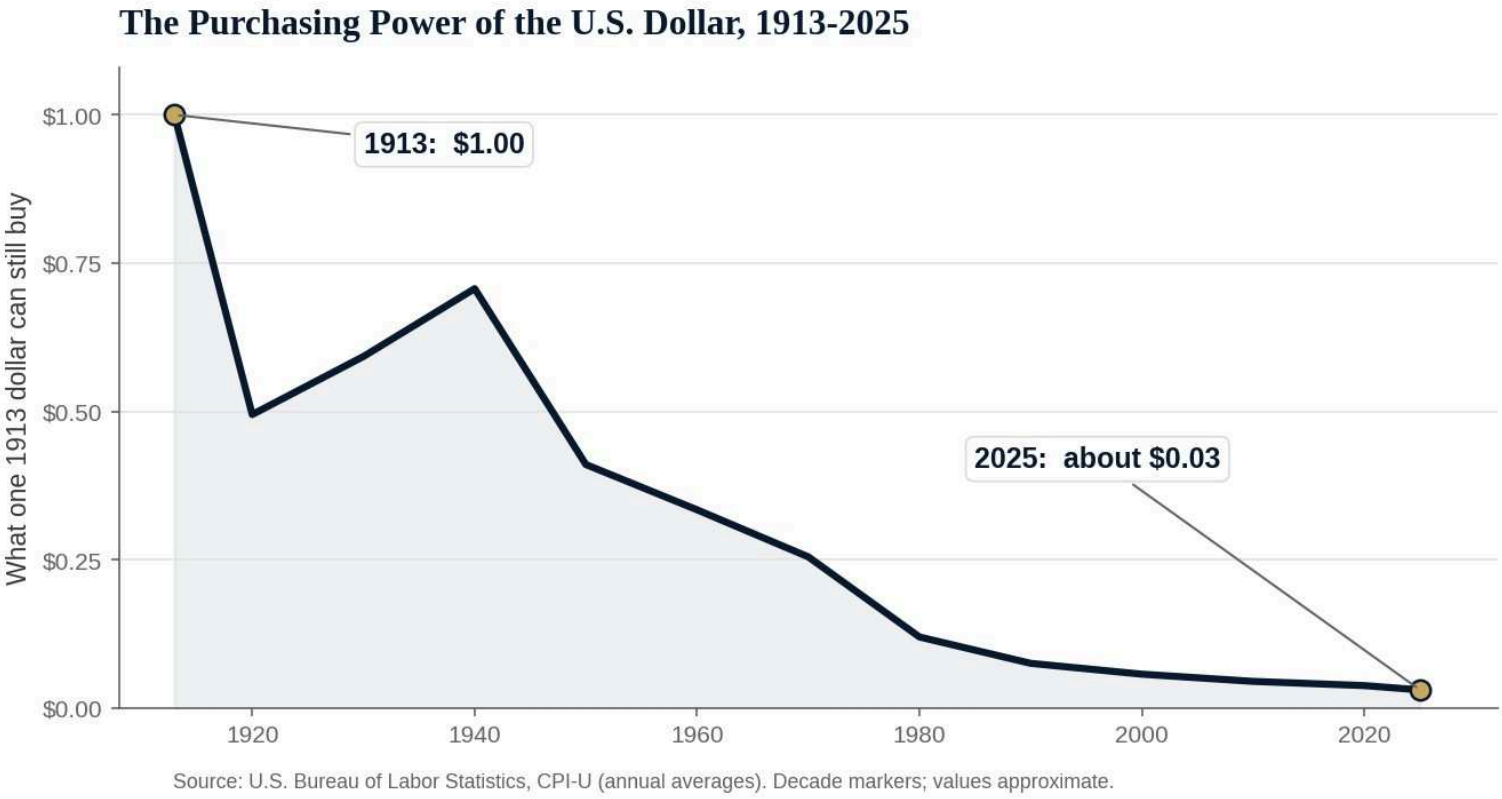
Today there is no map. For decades now, no one has been here before. No one has managed nearly forty trillion dollars in debt, a currency that has lost ninety-seven percent of its life-force, and a population where Social Security carries seventy million people.

In 1913, a dollar was anchored. It was defined, backed, and tied to something real you could weigh in your hand. A little over a century later, that same dollar buys a small fraction of what it once did. Not because of one crash, one war, or one bad president, but because of a long, patient erosion that almost nobody notices while it is happening, precisely because it never happens all at once.

Two dates carry most of the story. In 1913, the system that manages the dollar was created, and from then on the number of dollars in the world could grow. In 1971, the last formal link between the dollar and gold was cut, and the dollar became what economists call a fiat currency, which is a polite way of saying money backed by nothing but confidence and the word of the people who print it. After that, there was no hard limit on how many new dollars could be made.

Here is the whole game in one sentence. When the number of dollars grows faster than the goods and services those dollars chase, each individual dollar buys a little less. That is inflation. Not a headline, not an emergency, but a permanent background condition built into the money you hold.

Nixon’s decision in 1971 changed what was possible. Before it, the government could only spend the money we gave it. After it, the government could solve its problems with money it created itself, and there was no longer a hard limit on how much of that it could do.
It is like burning the furniture to heat the house. It works. It works for a while. And then one morning you are warm and sitting on the floor.



The purchasing power of the U.S. dollar, 1913 to 2025. Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, CPI-U.

Look at that line. It does not spike and it does not crash. It erodes. Steady and downward, decade after decade, the way a riverbank goes without anyone watching it happen.

Now here is why that line matters more to you than to almost anyone else alive. A quiet erosion is survivable if you have forty working years ahead of you to earn fresh dollars and refill the bucket. It is a very different thing when you are retired, or nearly so, and drawing down savings you can never replace. The erosion does not politely stop on the day you collect your last paycheck. If anything, that is the exact day it begins to hurt, because now every dollar lost is a dollar gone for good.

This is not a fringe theory or a sales pitch. It is basic monetary history, the kind sober people have understood for a hundred years. Which leads to the only question that really matters. If the dollar is built to erode, what do careful people hold to protect the purchasing power they spent a lifetime earning? We will get there. But first, one more piece of the picture, because the quiet erosion is only half the danger.

SECTION 3

The Pattern That Keeps Repeating

If the dollar erodes in calm times, history shows it can evaporate in hard ones. And hard times are not rare. We have been living through a hard stretch since 2008. In the years since that crisis took hold, the national debt has grown from about ten trillion dollars to nearly forty trillion, close to thirty trillion dollars in new borrowing. Borrowing and money creation on that scale is what feeds the erosion this guide describes.

Put in plain numbers, a dollar from 1971 is worth only about twelve cents today. That is roughly eighty-eight cents of purchasing power, gone in a single working lifetime. Spread across those fifty-five years, it works out to an average of about a penny and a half lost every year.

Since the end of the Second World War, the American economy has passed through more than a dozen recessions. Thirteen of them. Sit with that number for a moment. Inside a single working lifetime, an ordinary saver has lived through thirteen separate downturns, each one arriving with its own trigger and its own frightening headlines, and each one quietly asking the same question. Will the money you set aside still be there, and still be worth something, when the dust settles?

Most were painful but survivable. A few were not. When you rank these downturns by the damage they did to household savings and retirement accounts, three of them stand apart from the rest. The deep ones. The ones that erased years of patient saving in a matter of months and then took far longer than anyone expected to climb back from. People who happened to be near retirement when those hit do not remember them as news stories. They remember them as the moment the plan they had counted on came apart. Some never made the ground back at all.

Now let me say the honest thing plainly, because you deserve it, and because anyone who will not say it is trying to sell you something. Nobody can tell you when the next recession will come, or how deep it will run. Not me, not your advisor, not the loudest voice on television. What the historical record does show, and all it shows, is this. Recessions are a recurring feature of the system, not freak accidents. And the savers who came through them steadiest were, again and again, the ones who had already decided what they owned before the storm arrived. Not the ones deciding while it was overhead. Preparation has always been something

always been something you do in the calm. That is the entire point of it. Not because anyone can see what is coming, but because nobody can.

There is one more thread that ties the downturns back to the quiet erosion. Look at how the worst of them were answered. The response, almost every time, was the same. Create more dollars. More dollars to steady the banks, more dollars to restart spending, more dollars to keep the machine turning.

And often it was necessary. That is the honest part, the part nobody says out loud. To stop the pain that was coming, the dollars had to be made. But necessary is not the same as free. Every one of those dollars was borrowed against something, and the thing it was borrowed against was the value of the dollars already sitting in your account. Quietly, like evaporation.

That is the part that never makes the press release. The cure for the crisis feeds the erosion. The medicine and the disease are the same substance, and the government, in the act of solving the problem, becomes the author of it. Consider one promise alone. Social Security now supports roughly seventy million Americans, and the number grows every year. Every check it sends is paid in dollars, and every dollar summoned to send them draws once more from the same well. You do not need a collapse for this to matter. You only need time. A dollar drawn down this way does not disappear overnight. It loses ground, year after year, against everything you were counting on it to buy.

Which leaves one fair and uncomfortable question for anyone whose life savings are held entirely in dollars. In that moment, what protects me?

SECTION 4

Why Safe Money Is Not as Safe as It Sounds

When most people decide to protect their retirement, they reach for the same instinct. Get conservative. Come out of stocks. Move into cash. Hold bonds. Play it safe.
It is a good instinct, and I would never talk anyone out of prudence, because prudence is exactly right. But there is a catch buried inside that instinct that almost no one points out, and it is important enough to stop and look at directly.

Cash. Money market accounts. CDs. Most bonds. Nearly every instrument people reach for when they want to feel safe shares one hidden trait. Every one of them is denominated in dollars. They do not protect you from the dollar's quiet erosion. They ride along with it. A dollar sitting in a savings account and a dollar folded under a mattress face the exact same erosion. One of them simply pays you a little interest for the privilege of watching it happen. If the purchasing power of the dollar itself is drifting down year after year, then getting safe by holding more dollars is a little like escaping the rain by standing under a different patch of the same sky.

Let me be clear about what I am not saying. I am not saying cash is worthless, or that you should hold none of it. You need cash. Everyone does. It is how you pay for groceries next week and handle whatever life throws at you next month. What I am saying is narrower and more useful than that. An all-dollar retirement carries a hidden, one-directional risk that most savers have never once had explained to them. Every "do not put all your eggs in one basket" rule you have ever heard applies here too. The basket does not have to be a single stock or a single company. It can be a single currency.

So the real question was never stocks or bonds, cash or CDs. Those are all just choices made inside the dollar. The deeper question underneath every one of them is whether it makes sense to hold something outside the dollar entirely. Something whose worth does not rise and fall with how many new dollars get printed next year. Something that has held its value not for a decade, not for a generation, but across the whole long sweep of recorded history, through every paper currency that was ever born, rose, and quietly died around it. That is where we turn next.

SECTION 5

A Word From Larry Kudlow

Everything in this guide so far is monetary history and plain arithmetic. You do not have to take it on faith, and you do not have to take it from us.

Larry Kudlow spent his career inside these questions. He worked in the Reagan administration, served as Director of the National Economic Council, and has spent decades on television explaining the American economy to ordinary people in language they could actually use. He is not a gold salesman and he never has been. He is, in fact, famous for his optimism about this country and its currency, which is exactly why his view on this subject is worth your attention. When a man who has spent forty years making the case for American economic strength tells you that the purchasing power of your dollars is under real pressure, that is not a sales pitch. That is a warning from someone with no reason to sound one.

Here is what he says about it, in his own words.



Larry Kudlow

Host of Fox Business Network's "Kudlow"

"Inflation is too many dollars chasing too few goods. Years of deficits, spending, and monetary expansion have put pressure on the dollar's purchasing power. That's why gold has served as a timeless store of value because you simply can't print more of it. For people who've worked hard and saved for retirement, holding some physical precious metals in a self-directed IRA is a sensible way to diversify and protect against the erosion we've seen in fiat currencies. It's not about getting rich quick; it's about preserving what you've earned."

Paid endorsement. Larry Kudlow is compensated by American Sovereign Bullion for his endorsement. His statement reflects his own views. Individual results vary, and precious metals can lose value.

Read that last line again, because it is the whole argument of this guide compressed into a single sentence. It is not about getting rich quick. It is about preserving what you have earned.

Notice what he did not say. He did not say the dollar is finished. He did not tell you to sell your stocks, empty your accounts, or run for the hills. He said something far more measured, and far more useful to a person in your position. He said that a portion of what you have worked for belongs in something that cannot be printed. That is the entire case, and it is a modest one. The rest of this guide simply shows you how it works.

SECTION 6

The One Thing Built to Hold Its Value

For five thousand years, across every continent and every civilization, human beings who wanted to store the value of their work in something that would not rot, rust, inflate, or default reached for the same thing.

Consider what it is you would be holding. The gold in your spouse's ring, in the coins in a depository, in the bar in a vault, is older than the ground you are standing on. It was forged in the death of a star and it arrived here before the Earth had finished forming. No process on this planet can manufacture it in any quantity that matters. Every ounce that exists, existed before there was anyone alive to want it.

Five thousand years ago men dug it out of the ground and understood immediately what they had. They have never once changed their minds. Empires rose and minted their coins and swore the coins were sound, and the empires fell and the coins became curiosities in a museum case, and the gold went right on being gold.

That is what we are talking about here. Not a product. Not a position. Gold.

Not because of superstition, and not because gold does anything useful in the way a machine or a share of a company does. Gold pays no dividend. It earns no interest. It sits in a vault and does nothing at all. That is not its weakness. That is precisely the point of it.

Gold is not the thing you buy to get rich. It is the thing careful people have always held to keep from getting poor. Its whole job is different from a stock or a bond. A stock is a bet on growth. Gold is a defense of what you already have. When the ground is steady, it simply sits there. When the ground moves, when currencies wobble and confidence cracks, it has a very long history of being the thing that still holds its worth after the paper around it has faded.

Here is the part that matters for the dollar's quiet erosion. Gold cannot be printed. No committee can vote more of it into existence to paper over a crisis. Its supply grows only as fast as it can be pulled out of the earth, slowly and at great cost. That single fact, that no one can simply make more of it, is the reason it has outlasted every fiat currency ever tried. The dollars erode. The gold does not.

And if you want to see the erosion with your own eyes, look at what has happened since Nixon cut the cord in 1971. Gold has gone from thirty-five dollars an ounce to roughly four thousand. In that same span, the Dow climbed from under nine hundred to over fifty thousand.

Most people look at those two numbers and immediately start arguing about which one they should have owned. That is the wrong argument. It is also, conveniently, the one you are supposed to have.

Ask the better question. What has to be true about a dollar for both of those things to happen at once? An ounce of metal that does nothing, sitting in a vault. A basket of the largest companies on earth. Two things that could not be less alike, and both of them up thousands of percent against the same currency inside a single working life.

The ounce did not change. The companies did not get sixty times better at making things. What changed is the ruler you are measuring them with. Those two numbers are not a story about gold and they are not a story about stocks. They are a photograph of what happened to your money.

Now, none of this means gold only goes up, or that its price cannot fall. It can, and it has, sometimes for years at a stretch. Gold is not magic, and this guide will never pretend that it is. What gold offers you is not a guarantee of gain.

It is something rarer, and at this stage of your life, arguably worth more. It is a piece of what you built that sits entirely outside the dollar. Unbothered by how many new ones get printed. Held in something no committee can vote to dilute while you sleep.

SECTION 7

Real Metal Versus Paper Promises

If you decide a portion of your savings belongs in gold, there is a fork in the road that most people never realize they are standing at, and it matters a great deal. You can own gold on paper, or you can own gold you can hold.

Paper gold is the convenient version. Certain funds, certificates, and accounts let you buy something that tracks the price of gold without you ever touching an ounce of it. It moves up and down with the gold price on your screen, and for a trader that may be fine. But read the fine print and you often find that you do not actually own metal. You own a claim. A promise from an institution that somewhere, on your behalf, gold exists. In calm times that distinction is invisible. In exactly the kind of moment you bought gold to protect against, a moment when institutions are strained and everyone reaches for safety at once, the difference between owning metal and owning a promise is the whole game.

Physical gold is the other road. Real coins and bars, of a weight and purity you can verify, held in your name. It is not a claim against a company that could fail. It is not an entry in a database that depends on a chain of middlemen staying solvent. It is the thing itself. If the power goes out and the screens go dark, it is still exactly what it was. A tangible object that has been money for five thousand years and needs no one’s permission to keep its worth.

For someone protecting a retirement, that difference is the point. The reason to hold gold at all is to own something that does not depend on anyone else keeping their word. A paper promise quietly hands that dependence right back. Physical metal, held in your name, is the version that actually does the job you bought it for.

SECTION 8

How to Hold Gold Inside Your IRA

Here is the news that surprises almost everyone who calls us for the first time. You do not need a pile of spare cash sitting around to own physical gold. You can hold it inside a retirement account, using money you have already saved. Done correctly, and depending on the accounts you hold, it can be moved without triggering a tax bill or a penalty.

It works through something called a self-directed IRA. A traditional IRA at a big brokerage typically limits you to stocks, bonds, and funds, which, as we have seen, are all denominated in the very dollar you may be trying to protect against. A self-directed IRA follows the same IRS rules and offers the same tax treatment, but it permits a broader set of assets, including physical gold and silver that meet the government's purity standards, held on your behalf at an approved and insured depository.

The mechanism for moving money in is a rollover. Done correctly, under existing IRS rules, you can move funds from an existing IRA, 401(k), or similar retirement account into a self-directed IRA without triggering taxes or penalties, because the money never leaves the retirement system. It simply moves from one qualified account to another and changes what it is invested in once it arrives. The metal is then stored in your name at a secure depository, insured and audited, and it is yours.

None of this is exotic, and none of it is a loophole. It is an established, entirely legal way for an American saver to hold a portion of retirement money in physical precious metal instead of in paper alone. The rules have real requirements, the eligibility depends on your specific accounts, and this is where a knowledgeable person on the phone earns their keep by walking you through your particular situation. But the headline is simple. The money you have already set aside can be put to work protecting itself.

One thing we will not bury. This is not free. There is a price for the metal above spot, a fee to open the account, and annual custodial and storage fees. You get the total, in writing, before a dollar moves.

SECTION 9

The Questions You Are Right to Ask

Careful people ask hard questions before they move a dime of their retirement, and they should. Here are the ones that come up most, answered straight.

Isn’t gold volatile?
Yes. Its price moves, and in the short run it can fall as well as rise, sometimes for a good while. Anyone who tells you otherwise is not being honest with you. But volatility over a week or a month is a trader’s concern. As a long-term store of value held for protection, across decades and through the currency shifts this guide describes, gold’s record is very different from its week-to-week wiggles. You are not buying it to trade it. You are buying it to hold it.

How do I know it is safe once I own it?
Physical metal in a self-directed IRA is stored at an approved depository that is insured and independently audited, with the metal held in your name. It is not sitting in a shoebox, and it is not a number on a screen that depends on one company staying afloat. You receive documentation of exactly what you own.

Is this a scam?
It is a fair thing to worry about, because there are bad actors in every corner of finance. The protection is to work with people who explain the rules honestly, put the costs in writing, never rush you, and are glad to answer every question before you commit to anything. If you ever feel pushed, treat that as your signal to slow down. A sound decision about your retirement does not have a countdown clock on it.

Why now?
Not because of a manufactured deadline. There is not one, and we will not insult you with one. The reason to look at this now is the simple logic of the whole guide. The dollar’s erosion is not pausing, the printing that feeds it is not slowing, and preparation has always been something you do in the calm, before you need it, rather than in the scramble after. The right time to check whether your savings are protected is while you still have the room to act calmly.

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SECTION 10

What to Do Next

If this guide has done its job, you understand something now that most Americans your age never have explained to them. A retirement held entirely in dollars carries a quiet, one-directional risk, and there is a straightforward, legal, time-tested way to protect a portion of it.

The next step is simple, and it costs you nothing but a phone call. Call American Sovereign Bullion. Talk to a real person who will listen to your situation before saying a word about product. Ask your hardest questions, the ones in this guide and the ones it did not cover. Find out whether moving a prudent portion of your retirement into physical gold and silver makes sense for you, specifically. If it does, you will be walked through the rollover step by step. If it does not, an honest specialist will tell you that too.

You spent a lifetime building what you have. You do not have to gamble it, and you do not have to panic about it. You simply have to make sure that a part of it, the part you cannot afford to lose, is held in something the dollar's quiet erosion cannot reach.



Call (844) 272-2428

Monday to Friday, 9 AM to 6 PM. Saturday, 11 AM to 2 PM Eastern.

Ask for a no obligation conversation about protecting
your retirement with physical precious metals.
Make the call while the choice is still calmly yours to make.

FOR THE RECORD

Footnotes and Sources

Every factual claim in this guide is listed below with the source it rests on. Where a figure is disputed or depends on how something is counted, that is stated plainly rather than smoothed over. Readers are encouraged to check any of it.

1. Section 2. The Consumer Price Index begins in 1913, the year the Federal Reserve Act was signed into law. Source: Federal Reserve Act of 1913; U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, CPI-U series, which the BLS begins in 1913 as the earliest year of the modern index.

2. Section 2. The end of the dollar's convertibility into gold. On August 15, 1971, President Richard Nixon suspended the convertibility of the U.S. dollar into gold, ending the Bretton Woods arrangement and completing the dollar's transition to a fiat currency. Source: Presidential address of August 15, 1971; Federal Reserve History, "Nixon Ends Convertibility of U.S. Dollars to Gold."

3. Section 2. National debt. Total gross U.S. national debt stood at $39.39 trillion as of July 6, 2026, which the guide states as nearly forty trillion dollars. The figure rises continuously and must be refreshed before each printing. Source: U.S. Congress Joint Economic Committee, Monthly Debt Update, July 2026; U.S. Treasury, Debt to the Penny.

4. Section 2. Social Security. Approximately 71 million people received Social Security benefits as of January 2026, and roughly 75 million including Supplemental Security Income recipients. The guide states seventy million. Source: Social Security Administration, Monthly Statistical Snapshot.

5. Section 2. The statement that no one has been here before. This refers to the specific combination of conditions, that is, debt of this scale, in a pure fiat currency that also serves as the world's principal reserve currency, with a population of this size dependent on federal retirement benefits. It is not a claim that currency debasement is new. Debasement is ancient and well documented, from the Roman denarius to the French assignats to the German mark of the 1920s, and every one of those episodes is part of the historical record the guide relies on. What is without precedent is the scale and the combination, not the practice.

6. Section 2, chart. Purchasing power of the U.S. dollar, 1913 to 2025. Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U), annual averages, 1982 to 1984 equals 100 (FRED series CPIAUCNS). The chart plots decade markers, not every year. Values are approximate and rounded.

7. Section 2, chart. The figure of roughly three cents. Cumulative CPI-U inflation from 1913 to the present is on the order of 3,300 percent, meaning the general price level is roughly 34 times higher than in 1913. A dollar today therefore buys a little under three cents of what a 1913 dollar bought. Source: BLS CPI-U; Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis inflation calculator. Figure to be refreshed against the latest CPI release before publication.

8. Section 3. Thirteen recessions since the Second World War. Counting the eight-month contraction of February to October 1945, the National Bureau of Economic Research chronology lists thirteen U.S. recessions from 1945 through the COVID-19 recession of 2020. Note on the dispute: some published sources report eleven rather than thirteen, because they exclude the 1945 wartime

demobilization contraction and, in some cases, treat the 1980 and 1981 to 1982 downturns as a single episode. This guide uses the thirteen count and the NBER chronology it rests on. Source: NBER Business Cycle Dating Committee chronology.

9. Section 3. The three most damaging post-war recessions by impact on household savings and retirement accounts. Drawn from ASB's internal recession reference analysis. Ranking basis and the specific three downturns to be confirmed against that document before publication, and the prose here is written to characterize rather than to name figures until that confirmation is made.

10. Section 3. The monetary response to downturns. The observation that severe recessions have consistently been met with monetary expansion is a characterization of Federal Reserve policy history, not a forecast. Source: Federal Reserve historical policy record, including the response to the 2007 to 2009 financial crisis and the 2020 COVID-19 recession.

11. Section 6. Gold as a store of value across roughly five thousand years. A widely accepted historical characterization based on the archaeological and monetary record of gold's use as money and as a store of wealth across civilizations. It is offered as history, not as a claim about future price.

12. Section 6. The origin of gold. Gold is not formed on Earth. It is produced in neutron star mergers and in rare supernovae, and the gold now present on Earth was already contained in the cloud of dust and gas from which the solar system formed roughly 4.567 billion years ago. It therefore predates the planet. Trace quantities can be produced by transmutation in a particle accelerator, at a cost far exceeding the value of the product, which is why the guide states that no process on Earth can manufacture it in any quantity that matters. Source: U.S. Department of Energy, Office of Science, DOE Explains: Nucleosynthesis; observations of the neutron star merger GW170817 (2017).

13. Section 6. Gold cannot be created by decree. Gold's above-ground supply grows only through mining, historically at a low single-digit annual rate, and cannot be expanded by monetary policy. Source: World Gold Council supply statistics; London Bullion Market Association.

14. Section 6. The statement that gold has outlasted every fiat currency ever tried. Precisely stated: gold has outlasted every fiat currency that has failed, and it predates every currency in circulation today. Some fiat currencies remain in use, including the U.S. dollar. The claim is about longevity and the historical record of failed paper currencies, and it is not a prediction that any particular currency will fail. Source: general monetary history.

15. Section 6. The 1971 comparison. Gold was officially priced at $35 per ounce in 1971, the year the United States suspended convertibility, and traded near $4,000 per ounce in July 2026. The Dow Jones Industrial Average closed 1971 near 890 and traded above 52,000 in July 2026, which is a rise of roughly sixty times, as the guide states. These two figures are presented together as evidence of change in the purchasing power of the dollar, and expressly not as a comparison of investment performance between gold and equities. Readers should note that the Dow is a price index and excludes reinvested dividends. On a total return basis, with dividends reinvested, U.S. equities outperformed gold over this period. Source: LBMA Gold Price historical series; S&P Dow Jones Indices. Prices change daily and must be refreshed before each printing.

16. Section 6. Gold's price can fall, including for extended periods. Stated explicitly in the text. Historical example: the gold price declined over a multi-year span following its 1980 peak and again following its 2011 peak. Source: LBMA Gold Price historical series. Past performance does not guarantee future results.

17. Section 7. Paper gold versus physical metal. Exchange-traded products and similar instruments that track the gold price generally give the holder an interest in a fund or a contractual claim, not title to specific, allocated metal that the holder may take delivery of. Terms vary by product, and the

governing prospectus controls. Readers considering any such product should read its prospectus. This guide's point is structural, that a claim depends on an institution performing, whereas allocated physical metal does not.

18. Section 8. Physical precious metals held in a self-directed IRA. Federal law permits certain gold, silver, platinum, and palladium products meeting specified fineness standards to be held in an individual retirement account, provided they are held by an approved trustee or custodian rather than by the account owner personally. Source: Internal Revenue Code Section 408(m), including 408(m)(3); IRS Publication 590-A and Publication 590-B.

19. Section 8. Rollovers and tax treatment. A properly executed rollover or trustee-to-trustee transfer between qualified retirement accounts does not, under current IRS rules, trigger a taxable event. Eligibility and treatment depend on the specific facts of the account holder's situation, and the rules can change. Source: IRS Publication 590-A. ASB does not provide tax advice.

20. Sections 8 and 9. Custody, and why the guide is precise about it. Metal held in a precious metals IRA is owned by the IRA and must be held in the physical possession of an approved trustee or custodian. An account holder may not take personal possession of IRA metal and retain its IRA status. In McNulty v. Commissioner, 157 T.C. No. 10 (November 18, 2021), the United States Tax Court held that an IRA owner who stored IRA-purchased American Eagle coins in a home safe, through an IRA-owned limited liability company, had received a taxable distribution equal to the cost of the coins. So-called home storage IRA arrangements are therefore not a lawful structure, regardless of how they are marketed. Metal a person wishes to keep at home is purchased with cash, outside a retirement account. Source: Internal Revenue Code Section 408(m); IRS Publication 590-A and 590-B; McNulty v. Commissioner.

21. Sections 8 and 9. Approved depository storage and metal eligibility. Metals held in a precious metals IRA must be held by an approved trustee or custodian at an approved facility, insured and independently audited, and recorded to the account. Only metals meeting the fineness standards of Internal Revenue Code Section 408(m)(3) are eligible, generally gold of at least 99.5 percent purity, silver of at least 99.9 percent, and platinum and palladium of at least 99.95 percent, together with certain specified government-minted coins. Metals that do not meet these standards are treated as collectibles and trigger the distribution rules regardless of where they are stored. Source: Internal Revenue Code Section 408(m); IRS Publication 590-A.

22. Section 8. Rollover eligibility, and the current employer restriction. A 401(k) held with a current employer is frequently subject to plan terms that prevent a rollover before separation from service or before a specified age, while a plan from a former employer generally may be rolled over. Plan documents govern, and eligibility depends on the individual's own accounts. Source: IRS Publication 590-A; individual plan documents. ASB does not provide tax advice.

23. Section 8. Costs and fees. A precious metals IRA carries costs. These include the price of the metal above the prevailing spot price, an account setup fee, an annual custodial fee, and annual depository storage and insurance fees. Amounts vary by dealer, custodian, and depository, and are quoted per transaction rather than published in this guide. ASB provides a total cost in writing before any funds are moved. Inadequately disclosed markups are a recognized problem in this industry and a recurring subject of federal and state enforcement, which is why the guide raises the subject in the body text rather than leaving it to the closing paperwork.

24. Throughout. Nothing in this guide is a prediction. No claim is made about the timing, depth, or existence of any future recession, inflation rate, or movement in the price of any metal. Statements about the past are stated in the past tense by design.

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WHAT TO DO NEXT

The purpose of this guide is not to persuade you of a conclusion. It is to place the facts within reach, each verified against primary sources, each numbered in the References at the end, so that you can make an informed decision about the form in which your savings will meet the next chapter.

If you would like to speak with a specialist at American Sovereign Bullion about protecting your savings in physical gold and silver, or simply to ask the questions raised by this guide, we are here:

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